

Pa. gives \$1 million to trees, trails in region

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By Don Hopey, Pittsburgh Post-Gazette

The state Department of Conservation and Natural Resources has awarded three grants totaling \$1 million to Pittsburgh area trail improvement, tree planting, and park enhancement projects.

DCNR Secretary Michael DiBerardinis announced the grants in Mellon Park in Downtown Pittsburgh today, saying that the projects will enhance the region's environmental and economic future.

The Regional Trail Corp. was awarded \$500,000 to help construct 1.3 miles of the Great Allegheny Passage, including a new bridge to cross the Norfolk Southern Railroad's active rail line in Duquesne.

The Pittsburgh Parks Conservancy received \$250,000 to help restore historic trails and bridges in Frick, Highland, Schenley and Riverview parks and to erect signs to increase accessibility by identifying the parks and their key features.

The TreeVitalize program in Pittsburgh was awarded \$250,000 for the TreeVitalize partnership with the Western Pennsylvania Conservancy, Allegheny County and others to plant 20,000 trees over the next five years and continue efforts to increase the region's tree canopy.

Funding for the grants comes from the Growing Greener II bond issue and Keystone '93, a DCNR fund generated from a portion of the state's realty transfer tax.

The announcement of the grants coincides with the International Urban Parks Conference, which started Sunday at the Hilton, in Downtown Pittsburgh, and runs through Wednesday.

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